Preserving the Past, Planning the Future: Marlfield House Hotel at a Strategic Crossroads

This case was written by Beau under the supervision of Dr. Eoghan O'Grady, Senior Lecturer in Strategy and Leadership at the Faculty of Business, Technological University Dublin. It was written solely to provide material for class discussion. The author does not intend to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a managerial situation

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Gorey, Co. Wexford – February 2025
Rain tapped gently against the windows of Marlfield House as Laura glanced at the time. In just over an hour, she and Margaret would sit down for their quarterly strategy review — not with a formal board or external consultants, but with each other, across the same oak table where their parents once hosted guests for dinner. The dining room, usually filled with clinking glasses and the soft murmur of conversation, was quiet this morning. Laura had been up early, walking the grounds, clearing her head. As she passed the pond suites, she thought about how much the hotel had evolved — and how much still rested on their shoulders. Staffing pressures, an increasingly digital marketing world, and the slow but steady realisation that succession could no longer remain a "someday" topic — these weren't new challenges, but they were starting to feel more urgent.

She pulled open her laptop and typed the first words into a blank agenda:
"What happens next?"

Introduction: The Enchantment of Marlfield House

Tucked away on the edge of Gorey, Co. Wexford, Marlfield House stands as one of Ireland's finest examples of a luxury boutique country house hotel. Once a private estate with roots stretching back to the early 1800s, it now blends heritage with hospitality — welcoming guests seeking everything from romantic weekends to countryside weddings. Its 36-acre estate, framed by woodlands and formal gardens, offers not only a rich historical backdrop but a uniquely personal guest experience.

Yet behind the elegance and serenity lie a set of challenges familiar to many family-run businesses. From navigating staff turnover and marketing demands to managing a looming question of succession, Marlfield faces critical decisions that will shape its future. How does a business this steeped in tradition stay relevant in a digital, experience-driven world? And how does a family plan for continuity without losing the charm and intimacy that makes the business special?

This case explores the operational realities and strategic crossroads facing Marlfield House today — offering a lens into the balancing act between legacy and reinvention in Ireland's boutique hospitality sector.

The Genesis: A House Built on Heritage

Built-in 1820, Marlfield House is a Regency-style country manor originally constructed as a dower house for the nearby Courtown Estate. Over time, it became the principal residence of

the Earls of Courtown, a prominent Anglo-Irish aristocratic family whose lineage traces back to military service under Oliver Cromwell and, later, King Charles I. By the late 19th century, Marlfield was their primary Irish residence, particularly after the larger Courtown House — just three miles away — fell into decline and was eventually demolished in 1948.
The house was part of a wider system of aristocratic estates that once dominated the Irish countryside. During the 19th century, the Stopford family, like many landowners, benefited from tenant rents across thousands of acres. But the Great Famine (1845–1849) and the rise of the Land League in the decades that followed began to unravel that model. As land was gradually returned to the people, estate incomes dwindled and the grandeur of houses like Marlfield became difficult to maintain.

Renaissance through Restoration: The Bowe Era Begins

The turning point came in the 1970s when Mary and Ray Bowe purchased the estate. Seeing its potential, they embarked on an ambitious restoration project to preserve the house's heritage while transforming it into a luxury destination. This marked the beginning of Marlfield House's new identity as a boutique hotel, combining historical charm with modern hospitality. Mary, from Castlepollard near Mullingar, studied at the renowned Shannon School of Hotel Management. She later met and married Ray Bowe, a native of County Waterford. Ray initially worked as the manager of the North Slob, where the family first lived, before taking on managerial roles at County Wexford Marts and later serving as a partner at Slaney Foods for several years.

The Bowes' first hospitality project was building and opening Esker Lodge in Curracloe in the early 1970s as a family home and guest house, later adding a restaurant which catered for holiday visitors to the seaside area and earned Mary a reputation for her cooking ability and hospitality. But Mary had the grand ambition of opening a country hotel, and when Marlfield House, with its 36 acres of gardens, came on the market in 1977, it was the perfect setting as the backdrop to her dream. Mary and Ray spent eight months renovating the house before opening with 11 bedrooms and a restaurant where Mary was the main chef and Hostess.

Marlfield House has long attracted a diverse clientele, welcoming guests from Irish Presidents to Hollywood icons like Steven Spielberg and Tom Hanks during the filming of Saving Private Ryan. Musical legends such as U2 and The Cranberries, along with James Bond actors Roger Moore and Pierce Brosnan, have also graced its grounds.

In 1989, the Property saw significant enhancements with the addition of a stunning Turner-style conservatory, six stately bedrooms, and a grand entrance hall, all designed in collaboration with the esteemed architect Alfred Cochrane. Mary further enriched the property by creating a man-made lake and introducing 32 breeds of ducks and wildfowl from the UK. This touch of nature inspired Marlfield's signature gold duck logo, which later influenced the name of its Duck restaurant. A kitchen garden was also established, producing fresh vegetables, herbs, and salads to complement the estate's formal rose gardens and surrounding wild woodlands, ensuring a seamless blend of beauty and practicality.

A New Legacy: The Modern Marlfield Narrative

Today, Marlfield is managed and run by Mary's two daughters, Laura and Margret. Margaret studied marketing at the College of Marketing in Dublin. She worked in conference management in the UK for some years, taking time out at one point to travel around the world while freelancing and eventually returning to Marlfield in the mid-1990s to assist her mother. Laura studied at the Chelsea College of Art in England and worked as a set designer in London for several years before returning home to work in Marlfield. Laura returned to work at the family business 20 years ago, and Margaret and Laura took over the running of it together in 2009.

Since then, Laura and Margret have taken charge of Marlfield House, stepping into leadership during a challenging period of economic recession. Despite the initial hurdles, they gradually made their mark on the business. In 2015, they transformed the courtyard buildings into The Duck Terrace Restaurant, introducing a relaxed, bistro-style dining option to complement the fine dining restaurant in the main house. Their efforts didn't stop there—they also renovated the gate lodge into a luxurious two-bedroom cottage, offering guests a unique and private stay. Marlfield remains a proud member of Ireland's Blue Book and the prestigious Relais & Chateaux hotel group, underscoring its commitment to excellence and luxury hospitality. With only 6 Irish members, Relais et Chateaux is a significant mark of quality and is considered one of the most prestigious hotel groups in the world, with members from over 60 countries worldwide. Marlfield House has also become a favoured wedding venue, providing the most romantic setting imaginable for marriage celebrations and photographs, and weddings are now a large and welcome part of the business.

Today, the guests who stay at Marlfield House predominantly come from around Dublin, whereas twenty years ago, when Margaret returned to Gorey from London, about 60% were American. At that time the network of roads made it less likely Americans would travel directly from Dublin Airport to the west or southwest. A stop-off in Wexford served them well. Also, there were 12 Relais and Chateaux hotels in the country, providing a great loop of hotels for RC loyal guests. Today travellers can get from Dublin to Galway in a few hours and the west and southwest are still the most desired destinations in Ireland.

Elegant Positioning: Market and Offerings at Marlfield House

Marlfield House is positioned as a luxury country house boutique hotel, attracting a predominantly affluent audience. Many guests come for romantic weekends away, special celebrations, or simply to enjoy the calm of the countryside. Its reputation is built on old-world charm, warm hospitality, and attention to detail — something that sets it apart in a crowded and competitive market.

The main house offers 18 bedrooms, each individually styled with antique furniture, rich fabrics, and period paintings. Guests wake to views of the lake or gardens, with marble bathrooms and king-sized beds adding a layer of quiet indulgence. In 2022, Marlfield introduced its Pond Suites — large, open-plan rooms tucked into a wooded corner of the estate. These suites have floor-to-ceiling glass doors and private terraces, offering a more

modern experience and have proven particularly popular with younger guests looking for something luxurious but informal.
For families or small groups, The Lodge — a separate two-bedroom cottage on the grounds — offers privacy and flexibility. With its open fire, kitchen area, and garden-facing living space, it gives guests the feel of their own country retreat while still being part of the hotel experience.

Food plays a central role in the Marlfield offering. The Conservatory Restaurant has long been the hotel's famous dining space, serving classical cuisine with French and Mediterranean touches. Much of the produce comes from the hotel's own garden, and the room is flower-filled with white tablecloths, painted walls, and silver cutlery, reinforcing the sense of occasion. By contrast, The Duck Restaurant, which opened in 2015, caters to guests looking for something more relaxed. Built into the old courtyard buildings, it serves seasonal European dishes and attracts both locals and visitors who want a more casual but still high-quality experience. Guests can sit on the terrace with a cocktail or a glass of wine and take in the view of the gardens. In many ways, The Duck reflects a broader shift in dining culture — where more people are going out regularly and want good food without the formality.
Afternoon Tea remains a staple of the Marlfield experience, served in the drawing room or out on the terrace when the weather allows. Guests are greeted with bone china, crisp linens, and homemade cakes, all set against the backdrop of the gardens.

The hotel sits on 36 acres of grounds, which include woodland walks, an ornamental lake, and formal rose gardens. Peacocks, ponies, and hens roam the property, adding a gentle rhythm to the place and giving children something to discover while adults relax. For many guests, the grounds are part of the magic — a chance to slow down and reconnect with nature.

Market Context

Situated just over an hour from Dublin, Marlfield House operates in a highly competitive hospitality space. Its appeal as a boutique luxury destination places it alongside a wide array of country houses, historic hotels, and wedding venues that also target discerning, experience-driven travellers. While Marlfield's charm lies in its family-run ethos and attention to detail, maintaining relevance in such a landscape requires consistent differentiation and strong brand identity.

Suppliers

The Duck Terrace Restaurant at Marlfield House is dedicated to using high-quality Irish produce, showcasing the best of local and regional ingredients. Suppliers are carefully chosen from Wicklow, Wexford, Carlow, and surrounding areas, ensuring fresh, seasonal products throughout the year. The restaurant's kitchen garden also provides a substantial portion of vegetables, herbs, and berries during late spring, summer, and early autumn.

Marlfield House takes pride in sourcing its ingredients with care and intention, drawing from a network of trusted suppliers that reflect both local provenance and culinary quality. The hotel's seafood arrives fresh from Duncannon Fish and Atlantis Seafood Co. in Wexford, while meats are supplied by Slaney Valley and O'Neills, also based locally. Poultry comes from Glin

Valley in Cork, and game is delivered by Wild Irish Game Co. in neighbouring Wicklow. Much of the fruit, vegetables, and herbs used in the kitchens are grown on-site in Marlfield's own garden, supplemented by local producers such as Cullens and Keelings. Seasonal berries are picked both from the grounds and Greens Berry Farm in Gorey. Marlfield's dairy, including cream, butter, and cheeses, are sourced from regional producers like Killowen Farm, Wexford Creamery, and Coolattin Cheese. Eggs come from free-range hens reared by neighbouring farmers, Samuel and Maurice Allen. To complement the Irish ingredients, Marlfield also imports select cured meats, olives, and oils directly from artisan producers in Luciano, Southern Italy — striking a thoughtful balance between local and international flavours.

Challenges in Paradise: The Quest for Staff Stability

Staff retention has emerged as one of the most pressing challenges at Marlfield House. With a turnover rate of approximately 30% — double the industry average of 15% — the hotel faces a persistent cycle of recruitment, onboarding, and training. For a boutique business that prides itself on delivering a warm, consistent guest experience, this level of staff movement poses both an operational strain and a strategic risk.

Marlfield House employs 65 staff, with 27 full-time and 38 part-time employees spread across key departments — including front office, housekeeping, culinary teams for both the Conservatory and Duck Restaurants, gardening and maintenance, and management. These teams work together to uphold the refined yet relaxed atmosphere that defines the hotel's brand. However, staffing consistency is increasingly difficult to maintain.

As Laura explained, *"Staff turnover has become one of our biggest headaches. We've had to reduce our opening days to Wednesday through Sunday simply because we don't have the numbers to sustain a full week."* The issue is made worse by the hotel's rural location in Gorey, which presents lifestyle and commuting challenges for employees. Public transport is limited, and the perception remains that greater career progression and better amenities lie in larger cities.

Laura observed, *"We often get wonderful young people who treat this as a stop-gap. They get great experience, but then they leave for Dublin or Galway."* This trend is especially visible in roles such as housekeeping, front office, and food and beverage, departments typically staffed by younger workers who see Marlfield as a short-term stepping stone.

The boutique nature of the hotel creates limitations in terms of upward mobility. Many employees — particularly younger staff — view their roles at Marlfield as temporary due to the limited promotion pathways in a small, family-run structure. Without the scale or hierarchy of a chain hotel, progression is difficult to define, and for some, that signals a lack of long-term potential. While Marlfield offers a beautiful working environment and strong team culture, feedback from exit interviews and informal conversations suggests that recognition, responsibility, and personal development opportunities are equally important to staff. Sometimes even more so than pay alone. These are key elements of intrinsic motivation, and their absence contributes to the broader retention problem.

High staff turnover affects Marlfield on multiple levels. New hires typically take several months to adapt to the hotel's standards and service expectations. During these transitions, service inconsistencies can arise, something that repeat guests are quick to notice. The remaining staff often bear the brunt, taking on extra duties that increase the risk of burnout. Training costs add up, and management must constantly juggle rotas to cover shortfalls. *"There are some weeks where I spend more time on scheduling than anything else,"* Laura admitted, *"and that's not where I should be focusing my energy."*

Currently, the hotel relies on an employee referral scheme to bring in new hires, offering a bonus to staff if their referred candidate passes a six-month probation period. It also uses job platforms such as Jobs.ie and Indeed.ie and recruits through agencies for senior roles. Marlfield's participation in European apprenticeship programmes adds some short-term capacity, particularly in the kitchen, but these placements are not a long-term solution.
Laura reflected on the deeper issue: *"What we really need is not just more staff, but a way to keep the ones who love hospitality and want to grow with us. That's the heart of the problem."*

Inconsistent staffing not only affects service in the short term but also threatens Marlfield's long-term positioning as a premium boutique hotel where personalised, seamless guest experiences are a key differentiator.

Digital Age Marketing: Crafting the Marlfield Saga Online

As tales of Marlfield House weave through digital realms, the strategy shifts to capturing hearts in bytes and clicks. Laura and Margaret navigate the complexities of modern marketing, from enchanting potential guests via social media to crafting email campaigns that resonate with Marlfield's ethos.

Marlfield House has long relied on its rich heritage and personalised guest experiences to attract visitors. However, the rapidly evolving digital landscape presents both challenges and opportunities for its marketing efforts. With social media now a primary channel for travel inspiration and planning and businesses increasingly focused on marketing efficiency and measurable ROI, Marlfield must adapt to stay competitive. While its current efforts have shown respectable results, expanding and refining its digital strategy could unlock significant potential for growth in areas like corporate retreats and destination weddings. The hotel has developed a distinct presence in the luxury boutique market, combining digital and traditional marketing channels to reach its audience. Its picturesque setting, historic charm, and attention to detail make it an appealing choice for couples, families, and event planners alike. Marlfield currently operates at an average occupancy rate of 80% during the peak season (May to September), which drops to approximately 58% in the off-season. The hotel also closes for the month of January each year, making proactive marketing especially important in shoulder seasons.

Marlfield's digital marketing is centred on a few key platforms. It uses Ezines, an Irish email marketing software, to send targeted email campaigns to its subscriber base, sharing updates, seasonal promotions, and bespoke packages. On social media, Marlfield has cultivated a following of 15.5k on Instagram and 21.9k on Facebook, with content that showcases its

gardens, culinary experiences, interiors, and special events. The hotel also invests in Google Ads and seasonal radio advertising campaigns, especially around high-traffic periods like Christmas, where gift voucher sales and festive offers are heavily promoted.

Despite this diverse marketing toolkit, all marketing operations are currently managed by Laura and Margaret, who both oversee day-to-day hotel operations. This dual role stretches them thin and often limits the strategic potential of Marlfield's marketing activities. Laura has deep insight into the brand and its tone, but the demands of operational management leave little time for consistent content creation, campaign planning, or performance tracking. As Laura admitted, "I do love the marketing side of things, but the reality is I often find myself writing Instagram captions at 10pm after service."

Marlfield also maintains membership in two prestigious hospitality associations: Ireland's Blue Book and Relais & Châteaux. The Blue Book is an exclusive collection of country houses, historic hotels, and restaurants, while Relais & Châteaux is a global network of independently owned luxury properties known for exceptional service and cuisine. Membership in these organisations enhances Marlfield's credibility among luxury travellers and opens up marketing reach through association platforms. However, the financial commitment is significant. The Blue Book costs €18,000 annually, and Relais & Châteaux costs €30,000. With marketing budgets under pressure, Laura and Margaret have begun to question whether these memberships deliver sufficient return on investment to justify the expense.

This raises important questions about Marlfield's marketing strategy. Should the hotel continue to manage everything in-house, or is it time to invest in dedicated support? Are high-cost memberships still essential in the age of social media and digital storytelling? And how can Marlfield scale its marketing efforts without compromising brand authenticity or operational focus?

Behind the Brand: Balancing Marketing with Operations

As Marlfield House reflects on its future, the challenge is no longer about recognising the importance of marketing it's about building the internal infrastructure to deliver it strategically and sustainably. While Laura's efforts have kept Marlfield's brand active and authentic online, the current setup lacks the support systems needed to move beyond maintenance into growth. This limitation has become increasingly apparent as the demands of digital marketing (analytics, consistency, content production, and seasonal campaign planning) outpace the capacity of any one person.
The question is not whether the brand has potential; it clearly does. The real issue lies in execution: How can Marlfield move from reactive marketing to a proactive, data-informed strategy? How can it balance storytelling with structure and charm with consistency?
As Margaret noted in conversation, "It's not just about putting up a nice photo anymore, it's about understanding what works, when to post, who we're targeting, and why it matters."

This moment presents an opportunity to reframe marketing not just as a function, but as a lever for strategic growth. That might mean bringing in part-time support to handle scheduling and analysis, freeing Laura to focus on high-impact creative direction. Or it might

mean investing in training existing staff on digital tools like Mailchimp, Meta Ads, or Canva Pro, to build internal capability without fully outsourcing the function.

It also raises broader operational questions: How can core services (housekeeping, F&B, guest services) be adjusted or cross-trained to give managers like Laura more strategic bandwidth? Could marketing interns, hospitality students, or content freelancers support short-term goals without overcommitting resources?

In short, Marlfield doesn't have a marketing problem — it has a marketing capacity problem. The brand, the voice, and the vision are already there. What's needed now is structure, delegation, and systems that allow the business to scale its marketing without sacrificing quality or burning out its leadership.

The Next Chapter: Succession Uncertainties at Marlfield House

As Marlfield House continues its legacy in the boutique luxury hotel market, the question of who will guide its future is quietly gaining urgency. Laura and Margaret, the sisters who have steered the hotel for decades, remain deeply embedded in its daily operations, shaping everything from the guest experience to the gardens. Yet, with both now approaching the later stages of their careers, the matter of succession is starting to move from background thought to real-world concern.

In many ways, the potential for keeping Marlfield in the family lies with Beau, Laura's son, who is currently finishing his degree in Business and Management at Technological University Dublin. He has grown up around the business, worked across departments on weekends and holidays, and more recently, begun thinking more strategically about its future through his academic work. Still, interest does not automatically equal intention. Beau hasn't formally committed to taking on the hotel, nor have Laura and Margaret pressured him to do so. As Laura puts it, "I'd love to see one of them take it on, but only if they really want it — this kind of work needs passion, not just inheritance." There's an openness and hesitancy that reflects the family's desire to let things unfold naturally.

Hannah, Laura's younger daughter, and Ava, Margaret's daughter, are both still in school, currently studying for their Leaving Certificate exams. While it's too soon to tell what paths they may pursue, neither is actively involved in the business at this stage.
At present, there's no formal succession plan. Leadership, ownership, and strategic decision-making remain in the hands of Laura and Margaret. While this has worked for decades, it also introduces a degree of risk, particularly if an unexpected event were to prompt a sudden need for transition.

There have been casual conversations about what the future might look like, including external management partnerships or, in more distant terms, a sale. But no concrete steps have been taken. The sisters are well aware of the need to prepare, but have struggled to find the right balance between planning ahead and preserving the informal, personal nature of their work.

What's clear is that succession at Marlfield is not just about passing the baton, it's about preserving a culture, a reputation, and a way of doing things that's deeply personal. That makes the process as emotional as it is strategic.

The question, then, is not just *who* will lead Marlfield House next, but *how* the family can approach this uncertainty in a way that protects the business, respects individual aspirations, and keeps the door open to multiple possible futures. For Laura and Margaret, this includes carrying forward the legacy of their mother, Mary Bowe, whose vision and values shaped the hotel from the beginning. As the next generation — Beau, Ava, and Hannah — consider their futures, the hope is that Marlfield's story continues with the same care, elegance, and dedication that Mary first imagined.

The Way Forward

That evening, after the morning's strategy meeting, Laura moved through the quiet hallways of Marlfield, flicking off lights one by one. The house had settled into stillness — fires soft in the hearth, tables laid again for breakfast.

The meeting had surfaced more questions than answers: How to build marketing momentum without burning out? How to keep great staff when the industry pulled them elsewhere? How to think seriously — and sensitively — about who might lead Marlfield in the years to come?

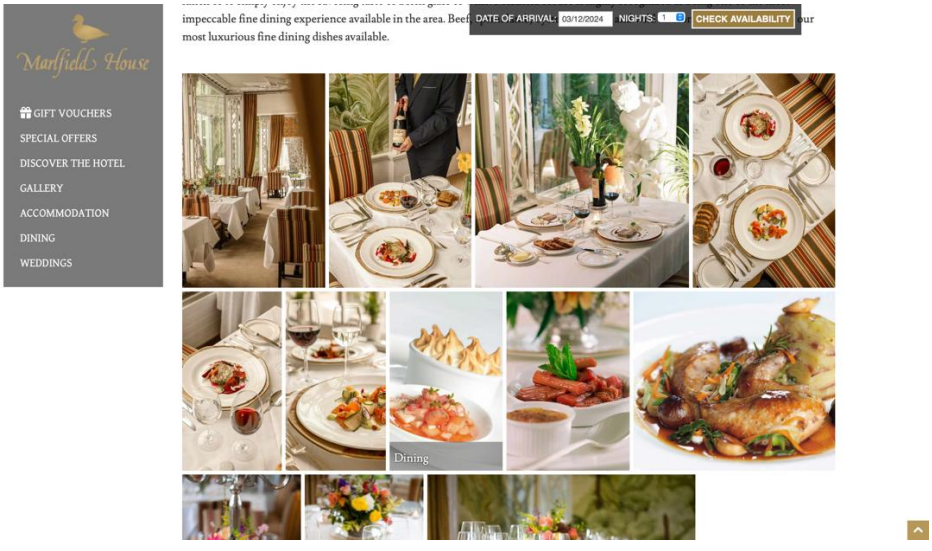
Beau had called not long after. Just a quick check-in. Curious, asking more questions than usual.

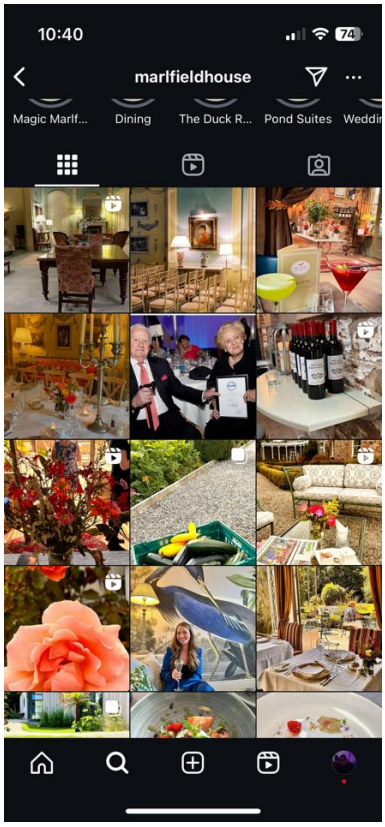
Outside, the garden was silvered in moonlight. As Laura turned the key in the front door, she looked back at the house — still, warm, waiting.

The future wasn't decided yet. But the conversation had begun.

Appendices




Marlfield House
GIFT VOUCHERS
SPECIAL OFFERS
DISCOVER THE HOTEL
GALLERY
ACCOMMODATION
DINING
WEDDINGS
impeccable fine dining experience available in the area. Beef
DATE OF ARRIVAL: 03/12/2024
NIGHTS: 1
CHECK AVAILABILITY
most luxurious fine dining dishes available.
Dining


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